sends a request from the user's computer to the server on which the web app is hosted, using the HTTP protocol.

DEFINITION The *hostname* of a website uniquely identifies its location on the internet by mapping via the Domain Name Service (DNS) to an IP address. Examples include microsoft.com, www.google.co.uk, and facebook.com.

A brief primer on HTTP

Hypertext Transfer Protocol (HTTP) is the application-level protocol that powers the web. It's a stateless request-response protocol whereby a client machine sends a request to a server, which sends a response in turn.

Every HTTP request consists of a verb indicating the type of the request and a path indicating the resource to interact with. A request typically also includes headers, which are key-value pairs, and in some cases a body, such as the contents of a form, when sending data to the server.

An HTTP response contains a status code, indicating whether the request was successful, and optionally headers and a body.

For a more detailed look at the HTTP protocol itself, as well as more examples, see section 1.3 ("A quick introduction to HTTP") of Go Web Programming, by Sau Sheong Chang (Manning, 2016), at http://mng.bz/x4mB. You can also read the raw RFC specification at https://www.rfc-editor.org/rfc/rfc9110.txt if dense text is your thing!

The request passes through the internet, potentially to the other side of the world, until it finally makes its way to the server associated with the given hostname, on which the web app is running. The request is potentially received and rebroadcast at multiple routers along the way, but only when it reaches the server associated with the hostname is the request processed.

When the server receives the request, it processes that request and generates an HTTP response. Depending on the request, this response could be a web